

Policy Recommendations

Derived from our findings, we make the recommendations detailed below. We attempt to cover all the key changes that need to be made to improve CFM implementation in Zambia and we structure our recommendations around the same four domains that the report focuses on, namely governance, SFM, economic transformation and equity and inclusion. We acknowledge that others may have made similar recommendations and we also note that efforts may already be in place to address some of the issues. However, our purpose here is to provide a comprehensive set of recommendations that arise from our work.

The recommendations below are intended for three key audiences. We indicate the primary intended audience: **[GRZ]** for government policymakers, **[FD]** for Forestry Department managers and district-level facilitators, and **[Practitioners]** for NGOs, carbon developers, and other development partners. Many recommendations are cross-cutting and relevant to multiple audiences.

Governance

High quality governance is essential to CFM. The state, through the Forestry Department, must provide adequate oversight to ensure CFM regulations are being followed and the agreed upon forest management plans implemented. CFMGs must comply with their own constitutions, implement financial and management actions transparently, and ensure equitable benefit sharing, as well as functioning grievance and redress processes. Private entities, such as carbon developers and conservation NGOs, must implement FPIC processes properly and ensure their actions support CFMGs in implementing good governance.

Institutional Capacity and Oversight

- **[GRZ, FD]** The FD should establish a national CFM unit to support implementation. This unit should focus on capacity development for forestry staff, so they are able to support CFM at the provincial and district level. In addition, forestry curricular for tertiary institutions, such as Copperbelt University and the Zambia Forestry College, need to be updated so that graduates are trained in CFM.

Monitoring and Compliance Tracking

- **[FD]** Transition the current CFM database into a digital management dashboard for CFM monitoring that can be integrated with digital data collection tools and file uploads. Ideally, this dashboard would have an associated App that would facilitate recording of data on common processes, such as CFMG meetings and elections, permits, workplans, budgets, annual reports, and so on. Information on compliance could be displayed using a traffic light system, which would enable district staff to quickly identify CFMGs requiring prioritized support and mentoring, and would provide an objective basis for tackling elite capture through improved transparency and accountability. Tracking CFM compliance is complicated and requires timely access to evidence collected through monitoring. Hence, the Forestry Department should make maximum use of digital tools to facilitate this process. Furthermore, these tools and information systems should be made available in multiple local languages to ensure accessibility across communities with varying literacy levels in English, and capacity-development for using these systems should be continuous and adaptive, incorporating feedback from users to improve monitoring approaches over time.
- **[FD]** District forest office staff should be required to visit CFMGs once per quarter and support the CFMGs in developing and implementing their budgets and workplans, as well as ensuring they are compliant with their constitutions and national regulations with respect to reporting, holding meetings and elections. They should be applying the “Checklists – CFM Step 7: Joint Monitoring, Evaluation and Lesson Learning”. CFM Step 7 serves as a critical quality assurance mechanism, verifying that CFMGs are fulfilling their obligations to protect, control access and manage their forests according to agreed management plans. Step 7 assessments also highlight gaps in earlier implementation steps (FPIC, boundary conflicts, user identification, constitution development, rules and sanctions, permits and fees). Key Performance Indicators for district office staff should be adjusted to reflect their role in the delivery of CFM support, with quarterly CFMG visits and reports as a measurable target.
- **[GRZ, FD]** Develop explicit performance standards for CFM implementation. While national guidelines provide recommended processes and expected outputs, formal performance standards should be established to enable monitoring of CFMG capacity and service provider performance. These standards should cover: (i) governance processes (elections, meetings, financial management); (ii) forest management actions (boundary maintenance, patrols, fire prevention); (iii) sustainable harvest of forest products; and (iv) benefit sharing and equity outcomes. Reference the example of performance standards developed for Participatory Forestry in Malawi, which enabled consistent monitoring across multiple CFA service providers and projects. Performance standards should be integrated into the monitoring dashboard and used to guide capacity building and support.

Private Sector Engagement

- **[GRZ, Practitioners]** Carbon developers and conservation NGOs should be required to provide support to CFMGs as a component of their business plans. The types of support should be standardised through regulations and guidelines, and should include support in CFMG governance compliance, forest management and enterprise development.

Budget and Financing

- **[GRZ, FD]** Funds need to be made available for regular district forest office staff visits to CFMGs and for implementation of improved monitoring and compliance systems. The financial justification for this investment can be framed in several ways: (i) CFAs function as long-term concession areas for community exclusive use, comparable to active timber concessions where the Forestry Department provides oversight — the same logic justifies investment in CFM oversight; (ii) the Forest Development Fund (established under Section 70(3) of the Forests Act, 2015) has explicit provision for promotion of community-based forest management practices, providing a potential domestic funding source; and (iii) the government’s carbon business plan should include a component for supporting improved CFMG governance as a necessary condition for realizing carbon revenues at scale. A portion of government revenue from carbon should be ear-marked specifically for CFM support, creating a dedicated funding stream.

Standardization and Transparency

- **[FD]** The appointment of district forest enterprise officers is a step in the right direction. However, these officers also need training, so that they can support the establishment and management of community-based forest product enterprises. The Forestry Department should work in tandem with the National Forest Commodities Association to develop models and associated training packs for different forest product value chains. Forestry enterprise officers should then be trained to deliver the capacity building required for each of these models.
- **[FD]** In line with the “Checklists – CFM Step 7: Joint Monitoring, Evaluation and Lesson Learning” implementation, increased standardisation of important CFMG processes would expedite compliance, simplify monitoring and reduce the risk of poor outcomes. Standardisation should cover: (i) election processes, tenure and term limits for CFMG members and executive positions; (ii) financial processes, including opening bank accounts, maintaining receipt books, payments to employees including HFOs, and gratuities to CFMG members and executives for participating in activities; (iii) reporting requirements, including presentation of annual financial and activity reports to community members; (iv) grievance and redress mechanisms; and (v) benefit sharing arrangements

for both carbon and other CFMG income. A number of these are already in the standard CFM agreement, but implementation is patchy, and many could be standardised to a much greater degree. Where more flexibility is required, the FD should publish guidelines, such as for different permitting arrangements and user-group management.

- **[FD]** To improve transparency and accountability, require publishing of decisions made at CFMG meetings and posting of these around the community. Minutes of CFMG meetings should also be uploaded to the FD's CFM database. Transparency in decision-making is a key governance marker and essential to addressing elite capture and ensuring equitable benefit sharing.
- **[FD]** Require that the district forest office staff and CFMG executives sign off on annual budgets and workplans by a specified date and submit them to the FD CFM database. This creates accountability on both sides and ensures baseline documentation for monitoring.

User Group Registration and CFMG-Enterprise Relationship

- **[FD]** Require registration and permitting of all forest user-groups, even if these are community groups and there is no intention to charge a permit fee. Formalising forest use and agreeing on management protocols, such as start dates and off-take levels, is essential for SFM.
- **[FD, Practitioners]** We recommend separating the role of CFMGs from income generating activities. CFMGs should focus on their core regulatory function — protecting, controlling access to and managing the forest according to agreed plans — while user groups and community-based forest enterprises operate as income-generating entities. This separation clarifies incentives, reduces role conflict, improves transparency, and enables the FD to better monitor CFMG compliance with forest management obligations. The relationship between CFMGs and enterprises should be clarified in forest management plans and user group agreements.
- **[FD]** Community-based forest enterprises should be explicitly tracked in the FD database and distinguished from the regulatory role of CFMGs. They should be set up as cooperatives or as businesses under the Patents and Companies Registration Agency (PACRA) with community shareholders.

Sustainable Forest Management

Sustainable forest management is one of the key objectives of CFM. Ensuring that CFMGs are taking management actions to protect and manage their forest resources is, therefore, essential. Boundary marking, patrolling by HFOs, fire prevention and other actions such as planting and restoration require annual budgets and workplans. Communities need to monitor boundary

incursions and fire incidence, and track NTFP off-take, as well as record any transgressions of by-laws, such as forest clearance or tree cutting, and track the actions taken against the perpetrators, such as fines.

- **[FD]** The district forest office staff and CFMGs should identify key SFM activities within the management plan and annual workplans and budgets — such as boundary marking, fire monitoring and patrolling — with completion dates for key milestones. These plans should be uploaded to the FD’s CFM database for monitoring. Progress on key SFM milestones should be tracked and reported through the national CFM dashboard.
- **[FD]** Annual reports should have a standardised format that includes reporting on SFM activities, linked to key milestones set in the annual workplans. This will enable comparison across CFMGs and aggregation at provincial and national levels.
- **[GRZ, FD]** CFM is a key mechanism for the government to deliver on restoration commitments, but currently this is not being adequately implemented or assessed. CFA boundaries should encompass areas that have restoration potential, such as areas that have been cleared or degraded through fire or charcoal production. The suitability of areas for restoration should also consider the ecosystem service delivery potential, such as watershed protection. CFMGs should identify restoration sites within the CFA in forest management plans. Any area that is substantially degraded when the CFA was established may be considered a restoration site. Within restoration sites, the management plan should identify areas for (i) natural regeneration (protection only) or (ii) planting with indigenous species or exotic species. If planting is planned, a business plan for harvesting the timber or other products should be developed to justify the investment.
- **[FD, Practitioners]** Establish community-based monitoring systems for NTFPs. The design of these systems should be standardised by the FD, so that data can be collected and aggregated at the national scale. However, monitoring should be implemented by the community using digital tools, and feed into a FD managed digital platform, with a dashboard for community viewing. The design of these monitoring systems should incorporate traditional knowledge held by community members about NTFP species, sustainable harvest seasons, and resource dynamics, and combined with scientific monitoring protocols to develop culturally-appropriate and effective approaches. Ideally, this dashboard would be integrated with the national CFM monitoring dashboard, rather than separate from it.
- **[GRZ, FD]** The FD should consider a small plantation programme or outgrowers schemes for CFAs for timber and sustainable charcoal production. These could be established on deforested land within the CFA and would contribute to Zambia’s plantation and timber production targets.
- **[GRZ, FD]** We found that deforestation rates prior to CFA establishment were very low, although >80% of CFAs were established to generate carbon credits. This raises the possibility that carbon developers are exaggerating the climate change mitigation

potential of their interventions. Zambia is already trialling approaches for establishing a jurisdictional approach for carbon accounting, and these results suggest it should be rolled out across the country as soon as possible to maintain credibility in Zambian carbon.

Economic transformation

The economic development of local communities through forest-based enterprises is, together with SFM, the other major objective of CFM. However, most community forest resource use, aside from charcoal, is for household consumption or perhaps for sale through local markets with little to no value addition. Through CFM, carbon finance has brought some local investment and direct income, but the substantial opportunity for developing enterprises around other forest resources is largely going to waste. For the Zambia government to realise its ambition for economic development through CFM, a much greater investment in supporting the establishment and management of community enterprises is required.

Market Development and Knowledge Support

- **[GRZ, FD, Practitioners]** The Forestry Department, in collaboration with the National Forest Commodities Association and other partners, should establish a national knowledge hub on forest product management, value addition, and marketing. It should help promote forest product innovation through research and technical support, and connect producers with buyers by organising forest product exhibitions at, for example, the annual agricultural shows at provincial and national levels.

Capacity Development

- **[FD]** Provide capacity development to district forest enterprise officers. They should receive training in management and value addition for forest product value chains, business skills and financial management.
- **[FD]** District forest enterprise officers should be required to provide capacity support for, at minimum, two forest value chains per CFMG. They should provide capacity development training for user-group members, and support them in business management, such as in financial management and reporting. KPIs should require quarterly visits to each CFA and documented capacity building activities.

Diversification and Market Access

- **[Practitioners]** To address the lack of diversity in forest product economic activities, encourage carbon developers and NGOs working with CFMGs to include a minimum of two forest product value chains in each CFA as a standard component of partnership agreements.
- **[FD]** Require the production and submission to FD of business plans for CFAs. These plans should be submitted alongside (or be a part of) the forest management plans that are required for CFA establishment. The format should be standardised to facilitate the maintenance of quality and so that comparable data can be extracted from them.
- **[FD, Practitioners]** Require community monitoring of harvested quantities of forest products for household use and for sale, using digital tools as described in the SFM section above. Data should be aggregated to assess sustainability of off-take levels and to identify emerging economic opportunities.
- **[FD]** Require recording of employment statistics, such as types of jobs and hours worked per month, as a component of the community monitoring. This will enable tracking of employment creation and identification of opportunities to improve job quality.
- **[GRZ, FD, Practitioners]** Develop a programme for community-based eco-tourism through CFAs and their intersection with national heritage sites. This should build on experiences at existing community-based eco-tourism sites, such as the M'panshya Campsite in Rufunsa and those run by Frankfurt Zoological Society in the North Luangwa landscape. CFM offers an opportunity to protect, and potentially restore, the environment around national heritage sites, while simultaneously promoting an eco-tourism enterprise to support income generation. The National Heritage Conservation Commission has a mandate to work with communities at national heritage sites, so there is a clear opportunity for collaboration between the Ministry of Tourism and the MoGEE in realising a common goal.

Forest Certification

- **[FD, Practitioners]** Consider promoting Forest Stewardship Certification (FSC) for CFMGs, but with realistic expectations. FSC certification can improve carbon credit values by up to 100% and open international markets for NTFPs. However, transaction costs for individual CFMG certification can be high. Hence, a group certification approach may be more cost-effective, which could be implemented through the FD if their monitoring and oversight of CFM is sufficient to ensure FSC compliance. Any FSC initiative should be paired with capacity building to ensure CFMGs can meet certification requirements.

Equity and inclusion

Equity and inclusion is a critical component of the social and economic development that should be achieved through CFM. First, the democratic processes involved in CFM, such as representation through the CFMG and participation in forest user-groups, give a voice to community members who might otherwise not be heard. Specific stipulations in the CFMG constitution can promote this further by requiring, for example, women or youth representatives on the CFMG and its executive. Second, forest resources often provide a safety-net for vulnerable community members, for example, by providing food resources at times of year when they experience seasonal hunger. Again, through representation, CFM can ensure these resources and the access rights of vulnerable community members are protected and also provide opportunities for vulnerable community members to participate in forest resource-based enterprises. However, with poor governance there are risks of elite capture and further marginalisation of vulnerable community members by excluding them from accessing essential forest resources. Hence, oversight of equity and inclusion provisions and their implementation is essential.

- **[FD, Practitioners]** Require identification of opportunity costs of CFM and the community members most negatively affected in the forest management plan, and require a mitigation plan for the impacts of these opportunity costs. This should be a specific component of the forest management plan and monitored through the national CFM database.
- **[FD, Practitioners]** Require consideration of vulnerable groups in the designation of forest user-groups and in the benefit-sharing arrangements. User-group formation should explicitly address participation by vulnerable households, including the elderly, people with disabilities, and those with limited social capital.
- **[FD, Practitioners]** Encourage and support development of women's and youth forest product enterprises. These could be supported through dedicated funding, capacity building, and market linkages to ensure that benefits from CFM reach beyond traditional power-holders.